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INTERNET OF THINGS

“Much Of The WEALTH Now LIES In TECHNOLOGY PRODUCT CREATION”

India is betting high on encouraging startups to promote unconventional thinking in the Internet of Things (IoT) landscape. What often goes unnoticed is the paramount task of mentors guiding entrepreneurs towards this path from behind the curtains. Dr Omkar Rai, director general, Software Technology Parks of India (STPI), in an exclusive chat with Rahul Chopra and Baishakhi Dutta sheds light on the various services and offerings for entrepreneurs to utilise in India

Q. You started with focusing on IT, and now we are seeing more and more enlargement of the scope to cover the IoT. What is the vision behind this?

A. STPI started with the promotion of the IT outsourcing industry. At present, it is a very mature industry, which is powering and serving many IT businesses in the world. Now, the focus is shifting for two main reasons.

First, India needs to promote electronics manufacturing because our import bill has grown a lot. And in times to come, it can grow even further if we do not manufacture within India.

Second, much of the wealth now lies in technology product creation, and therefore the world market in terms of technology product stands at US\$ 445 billion. India's share is merely US\$ 7.1 billion. This is why the whole incubation movement, startup movement or even the national policy on software products that has recently been approved by Union Cabinet of India are aimed at transforming India into a technology product nation. India is trying to capture a sizeable world market, which is being seen at US\$ 70 to 80 billion by 2025.

Q. What is the end goal that you are looking at with the help of this change?

A. Since the nature of entrepreneurship is changing, the nature of startups is changing, too. Hence, we are transforming our role to become a modern incubator that should be able to provide end-to-end services to startups. These services will be in



Dr Omkar Rai, director general, Software Technology Parks of India (STPI)

terms of product creation, right from screening process, manpower training, capital investment and exposure to global market.

Then comes facilities like market connections, access to capital and all. These are essential services that are required for startups of this time. This is being given by STPI, for which we are creating several centres of excellence (CoEs) in the country.

Q. Are the CoEs the same for separate areas of technology like artificial intelligence (AI), IoT, etc?

A. No! The CoEs are extremely focused. We are operating the electropreneur park in University of Delhi (south campus) in collaboration with India Electronics Semiconductor Asso-

ciation (IESA), through which we are trying to work with a large number of industry experts and veterans who are working with our entrepreneurs and startups. This is totally focused on electronic systems. We are opening another electropreneur park in Bhubaneswar because there is a large number of upcoming startups in that city.

Now, we are opening a CoE for AI and several other CoEs using the IoT in different domains, such as the IoT in agriculture, the IoT in rural application (horticulture), the IoT in smart city and others. So, the IoT is a technology that has to be deployed, used and capitalised to develop technology across domains.

Q. Does this mean that these CoEs are primarily incubation hubs?

A. Absolutely! These are incubation hubs because these will take care of all the needs of startups, right from sensitising the students to ideate in a particular manner. We create sensitisation across the country. Even in terms of our existing electropreneur parks, we do massive sensitisation and contact prospective entrepreneurs so that they are given a random glimpse into the kind of opportunities that exist, including areas where people need production services.

Q. What is the unique facility of the IoT Open Lab?

A. The IoT Open Lab is the second-of-its-kind in the whole world, first being in Hong Kong. The IoT lab will be open to not only startups who come in to our incubator but also to entrepreneurs operating from other facilities. Our IoT